

Physiconfig, Useful Handles, and Load-Bearing Ferrets

Support-Language Custody for Stable Human Variation

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Status: method paper draft for review

Boundary: support-language instrument. Not medical advice. Not diagnosis. Not service eligibility guidance.

Source base: internal Physiconfig, Useful-Handle Bullshit, Load-Bearing Ferret, autism polytrait, and support-route drafts; cited outside literature.

Abstract

Support systems often collapse distinct objects into one verdict. A stable body-brain form, the cost of carrying that form, the mismatch between form and setting, a service label, an acute state, and another person's discomfort may all be treated as if they name the same thing. This paper gives a custody method for preventing that collapse.

The method links three local concepts. **Physiconfig** names a stable configuration in body-brain trait space without making the configuration stand trial. **Useful handle** names a research, care, or coordination instrument that helps hold a messy object but does not settle the object. **Load-bearing ferret** names a handle that becomes infrastructure: silly, memorable, maybe useful, then quietly necessary to workflows, forms, scores, dashboards, service scripts, or model outputs.

The paper proposes a four-object split: **FORM**, **COST**, **MISMATCH**, and **SERVICE_GATE**. It then adds handle custody: every handle must state its route, limit, decision rights, non-decision rights, and removal test. The aim is not softer wording. The aim is object survival. A support need may be real. A service label may be useful. A person may choose treatment, training, setting change, medicine, rest, advocacy, or reduction of a costly trait route. None of those facts, alone, licenses a defect verdict on the whole form.

The contribution is a practical instrument for research and support settings: a support-route card, a handle card, and a ferret test for detecting when a useful phrase has begun to act as proof.

Keywords: support language, neurodiversity, disability, construct validity, infrastructure, audit, service gate, object custody

1. Problem

Many systems need categories. Clinics need intake terms. Schools need accommodation forms. Workplaces need access routes. Researchers need constructs. Families need sentences. Automated systems need labels. None of that is optional.

The problem begins when the category starts eating the object.

A label that began as a route into support may become a verdict about personhood. A score that began as a screening aid may become a decision. A phrase that began as a bridge between people may become a wall. A research construct that began as a model of some variance may become an essence claim. A service gate that began as an administrative route may become a story about what the person is.

This paper does not ask systems to stop naming things. It asks them to keep custody of what each name is allowed to do.

The base rule is:

```
support_need != defect_verdict
```

A second rule follows:

```
useful_handle != validation
```

A third rule keeps the infrastructure in view:

```
if a handle becomes load-bearing, removal must be planned before adoption is scaled
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2. Three terms

2.1 Physiconfig

A **physiconfig** is a stable body-brain configuration in multidimensional trait space. It is not a diagnosis, not a moral verdict, and not an exemption from care. It is a custody term for the object before service systems, observers, and crisis contact rename it.

The term protects a distinction:

```
FORM != COST
FORM != MISMATCH
FORM != SERVICE_GATE
FORM != ACUTE_STATE
FORM != OBSERVER_DISCOMFORT
```

A form may carry cost. It may be disabled by a setting. It may be helped by treatment, practice, medicine, assistive tools, or institutional change. It may need emergency contact in an acute state. The point is not to deny any of that. The point is to stop those facts from testifying against the whole form.

2.2 Useful handle

A **useful handle** is a phrase, model, score, checklist, analogy, diagram, service label, or audit field that helps people hold an object long enough to act.

Handles are allowed. Without handles, many objects stay too diffuse to support. The failure mode is handle drift:

this helps us hold the object
becomes
this has settled the object

The handle may still work locally. It may coordinate a team. It may get a person access. It may make a research paper writable. The problem is not usefulness. The problem is borrowed authority.

2.3 Load-bearing ferret

A **load-bearing ferret** is a memorable handle that has become part of the structure. It may be playful, awkward, provisional, or formally named. It may still be useful. But if removing it breaks the workflow, then it is no longer just language. It is infrastructure.

The ferret test asks:

What depends on this handle now?
What decisions use it?
What does it hide?
What does it invite?
What happens if it is removed?
Who gets stranded?
What replacement path exists?

The name is intentionally non-grand. That matters. Prestigious language hides dependency. A ferret leaves footprints.

3. Prior work

This paper sits between four literatures.

First, rights-based disability and community mental health work separates personhood, rights, support, and service design from deficit-only systems. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities gives a rights floor. WHO guidance on community mental health services ties care to person-centred and rights-based approaches. These sources support a service posture, not a new diagnosis.

Second, dimensional and construct-validity work gives tools for handling categories without turning them into essences. RDoC moved research attention toward dimensions and domains. Cronbach and Meehl, and later Messick, frame validity as a network of evidence and use, not a name that validates itself.

Third, neurodiversity and double-empathy work show why a person-setting relation matters. Milton's double-empathy problem makes misattunement relational rather than one-sided. Chapman gives a social-ecological account of mental functions. Strength-based autism work gives design routes that do not require a broken-average premise.

Fourth, work on bullshit, metrics, audit, and infrastructure explains handle drift. Frankfurt's account of bullshit as indifference to truth helps name the problem. Campbell, Goodhart, and Strathern show how measures and audit fields change action. Star and Ruhleder show infrastructure as something seen most when it breaks.

The local contribution is to combine these literatures into a small custody instrument for support language.

4. The four-object split

The first operational move is to split four objects that support systems often collapse.

FORM = the stable configuration

COST = what it takes to carry the configuration

MISMATCH = what the setting adds, blocks, or distorts

SERVICE_GATE = the label, score, or route needed for access

4.1 Form

Form is the body-brain pattern that persists across settings and time. It may include sensory gain, attention switching, movement release, boundary locking, social timing, sleep timing, language route, memory route, or body regulation.

Form is not automatically a problem. Form is also not automatically easy.

4.2 Cost

Cost is what the person pays to carry the form in a given life. Cost may be fatigue, lost time, pain, sensory overload, social translation load, shutdown, missed work, reduced options, or recovery time.

Cost is real even when the form is valid.

4.3 Mismatch

Mismatch is the setting-form relation. A school timetable, open office, interview format, fluorescent light, forced eye contact rule, phone-only service route, police encounter, waiting room, or bureaucratic form may create cost that is not located inside the person alone.

Mismatch does not prove the form is broken. It does show where route repair may work.

4.4 Service gate

Service gate is the administrative or clinical route that opens support. It may be a diagnosis, score, letter, code, eligibility phrase, workplace category, school plan, or benefits form.

A service gate may be necessary. It is not the same object as the form. It is also not the same object as support.

5. Handle custody

A handle earns local use by paying five rents.

ROUTE: what does it help do?

LIMIT: where does it stop?

RIGHTS: who may act from it?

NON_RIGHTS: what may not be inferred from it?

EXIT: how can it be replaced, retired, or narrowed?

A handle that cannot answer these five questions should not be scaled.

5.1 Handle card

HANDLE:
OBJECT HELD:
ROUTE:
LIMIT:
DECISION RIGHTS:
NON-DECISION RIGHTS:
PERSON-DESIRE GATE:
SETTING ROUTE:
REPLACEMENT PATH:
REMOVAL TEST:

5.2 Why this is not anti-label

The method does not reject labels. It rejects label overreach.

A label may be the shortest path to access. A score may begin a conversation. A category may let researchers compare findings. A metaphor may help a family stop blaming a person. These are real uses.

But each use must stay bound to its route. The same label may be suitable for support access and unsuitable for essence claims. The same score may be suitable for screening and unsuitable for final placement. The same phrase may be suitable inside a team and unsuitable as a public person-description.

6. Ferret test

The ferret test finds load-bearing handles.

A handle is load-bearing when at least one of these is true:

a decision fails without it;
a workflow stalls without it;
a form has no replacement field;
a team has no other shared object name;
a model reuses it as if it were ground truth;
a person loses access when it disappears;
an audit cannot say what the handle was allowed to decide.

The test is not “is this phrase silly?” The test is dependency.

6.1 Ferret card

FERRET NAME:
WHERE IT LIVES:
WHO USES IT:
WHAT IT CARRIES:
WHAT IT HIDES:

WHAT IT INVITES:
WHAT BREAKS WITHOUT IT:
WHO HOLDS EXIT RIGHTS:
NEXT SMALLER HANDLE:

6.2 Ferret repair

Repair has three steps.

1. Mark the handle as a handle.
2. Name the route it carries.
3. Build the next smaller handle before removal.

Removal without replacement may strand the person the handle was helping. Adoption without exit may turn a provisional phrase into a gate.

7. Worked route sketches

7.1 Sensory gain at work

Object contact:

FORM: high sensory gain

COST: exhaustion after open-office exposure

MISMATCH: lighting, noise, unplanned interruption, no recovery space

SERVICE_GATE: accommodation letter or workplace process

Bad collapse:

person is difficult

Better custody:

route cost is high in this setting

Support routes:

lighting control;

headphones;

desk placement;

remote blocks;

meeting buffer;

written task handoff;

recovery interval.

The form is not erased. The route is repaired.

7.2 Attention switching

Object contact:

FORM: high switching cost

COST: task re-entry time

MISMATCH: interruption-heavy workflow

SERVICE_GATE: performance plan, accommodation route, or task design process

Bad collapse:

low motivation

Better custody:

switching route consumes work time

Support routes:

batching;

written queue;

single-channel priority;

protected blocks;

handoff marker;

return note.

7.3 Boundary locking

Object contact:

FORM: strong lock around rules, consent, or sequence

COST: stuckness when the route is incoherent

MISMATCH: vague instruction, hidden social rule, moving target

SERVICE_GATE: support plan, coaching, mediation, or policy route

Bad collapse:

oppositional

Better custody:

the instruction route lacks enough structure to proceed

Support routes:

state the rule;

state who may change it;

state what counts as done;

state how to stop;

state how to restart.

7.4 Service label in school

Object contact:

FORM: mixed sensory, attention, and social timing profile

COST: school-day depletion

MISMATCH: crowded corridors, rapid transitions, oral-only instruction

SERVICE_GATE: educational plan category

Bad collapse:

the plan category is the student

Better custody:

the plan category opens a support route; it does not own the person

Support routes:

transition map;
written instruction;
quiet entry;
body break;
peer translation route;
end-of-day recovery plan.

8. Acute state and elected reduction

Physiconfig language needs two gates.

8.1 Acute-state gate

A valid form does not mean every state is stable. Sleep loss, overload, pain, intoxication, withdrawal, grief, infection, panic, or medication change may create an acute state. In that case the object is not “the form is bad.” The object is:

current state;
current body load;
current setting;
available support;
consent;
time course;
return path.

Support language should not hide urgent need. It should keep the acute state from rewriting the whole person.

8.2 Elected reduction gate

A person may choose to reduce a costly trait route, symptom, habit, exposure, workload, intensity, or setting contact. That choice does not prove the form was defective. It proves that the person has a target and a preference.

The gate is:

person chooses;
route is named;
cost is named;
tradeoff is named;
exit is possible;
review date exists.

9. Research design

The method yields research questions that can be tested.

9.1 Artifact genealogy

Trace a support term through drafts, forms, meetings, dashboards, and model outputs. Record when it changes from bridge to gate.

9.2 Route comparison

Compare two supports that share a label but repair different routes. If outcomes differ by route, the label was not the object.

9.3 Removal test

Remove or narrow a handle in a simulated workflow. Record which decisions fail, which supports remain, and which people lose access.

9.4 Person-setting split

Measure form features and setting features separately. Test whether cost changes more when the setting changes than when the person is re-described.

9.5 Service-gate audit

Audit whether a service label is being used beyond its decision rights. Count uses as access route, description, forecast, exclusion, funding key, discipline trigger, or model feature.

10. Falsifiers and narrowing tests

The method should narrow itself if these findings appear.

1. A handle with no stated route performs as well as a routed handle across settings.
2. Service labels do not drift into verdict use when tracked over time.
3. Support outcomes do not improve when FORM, COST, MISMATCH, and SERVICE_GATE are split.
4. Removal tests show no dependency on current handles.
5. People receiving support reject the split as less accurate than one-object labels.

If those appear, the method loses scope. If they do not appear, the method has work to do.

11. Output instruments

11.1 Support-route card

PERSON TARGET:

FORM:

COST:

MISMATCH:

SERVICE_GATE:

SUPPORT ROUTE:

WHO DECIDES:

WHAT CHANGES:

WHAT STAYS:

REVIEW DATE:

EXIT PATH:

11.2 Handle custody card

HANDLE:
OBJECT:
ROUTE:
LIMIT:
DECISION RIGHTS:
NON-RIGHTS:
PERSON-DESIRE GATE:
SETTING ROUTE:
REMOVAL TEST:
NEXT SMALLER HANDLE:

11.3 Ferret dependency card

FERRET:
WORKFLOW:
CARRIES:
HIDES:
INVITES:
BREAKS IF REMOVED:
REPLACEMENT:
EXIT OWNER:

12. Conclusion

Support language must do two jobs at once.

It must let people get support. It must also stop support routes from becoming person verdicts.

Physiconfig keeps the form from being put on trial by every cost. Useful-handle custody keeps instruments from pretending to be proof. The load-bearing ferret test finds the places where a temporary phrase has become infrastructure.

The paper's practical rule is simple:

Name the route.

Keep the object.

Do not let the gate become the person.

Internal source lineage

This v0.001 draft synthesizes the following internal source files:

extra_extra_expanded/physiconfig_not_disorder_v0_004.md
extra_extra_expanded/useful_handle_bullshit_v0_003.md
extra_extra_expanded/load_bearing_ferret_v0_001.md
extra_extra_expanded/autism_as_central_polytrait_basin_v0_004.md
extra_extra_expanded/autism_two_paper_next_bot_packet_v0_002.md

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